

## 10 Frugal Ways to Care for Your Allergies

I've had allergies for as long as I can remember. I have spent more days sniffly, snorty, with a scratchy throat and sinuses that feel like they're about to explode than many entire families. I've ended up with more ear infections, sinus infections, and cases of bronchitis than I care to recount. In fact, I take so much decongestant that my husband decided that my mutant power is Producing Snot.

And I've tried everything, from standard medicine to acupuncture to herbal remedies to homeopathy to staying in the house and shutting all the windows. The following are some things that work for me and won't cost you an arm and a leg. In this, the beginning of allergy season (well, for most of you . . . here in SoCal it's more like "The Middle of the Allergy Season That Never Ends"), I offer these suggestions in hopes that they also work for you.

1. **Alternate decongestants.** Decongestant products containing pseudoephedrine are sold behind the counter due to the fact that it can be used to make meth. Another new decongestant of choice is phenylephrine. Both help make nasal passages wider. Allergies can cause both symptoms, so your nose, throat, and sinuses will feel better if you treat them both. Since you aren't supposed to take them together, alternate dosages.
2. **Cut 12-hour pills in half.** Some pills containing pseudoephedrine are the 12-hour kind. (Is it harder to make meth from these? I don't know.) Sometimes, they actually work for 12 hours. But if they don't for you (like they don't for me—they work for about 8 hours and then I'm miserable for 4 until I can take more meds again), cut them in half and take them at 6-hour intervals.
3. **Buy decongestants at bulk stores.** I don't notice a difference in quality, even when I buy the store brand, and I pay much less than I would at the grocery store, pharmacy, or even discount store. I can get both daytime and nighttime pills that will last me between three and six months